

1625–1635

SOFTER SILHOUETTES

Fashions changed relatively slowly in the 17th century; but with the demise of the rigid farthingale petticoat, the trend in the mid-1620s to mid-1630s was towards a more bulky, soft silhouette, and dresses with higher waists and fuller sleeves. During this period dresses could be made up of three separate parts: a bodice, a petticoat, and a gown over the top (which might be gathered up to reveal the petticoat below). Another style was to wear the gown hanging from the shoulders. As with men's fashion, the ruff gave way to the broad falling collar edged with elegant handmade lace. Only in the Dutch United Provinces (now the Netherlands) was the ruff retained as the neckwear of choice. The fabric used in European fashionable dress in the 17th century was produced in many countries, with silk satins and velvets designed and woven in France and Italy, and linen for shirts and smocks made in the Netherlands and Germany.



Old fashioned This lady, possibly a Genoese marchioness, wears the dated style of European royal courts of the late 16th century. The bodice was a separate garment, stiffened with buckram or pasteboard, and sometimes with a central wooden busk.



Cartwheel The ruff was a fashion that persisted in the Netherlands in the mid-17th century, while in the rest of Europe it was dying out. It grew ever larger, becoming a cartwheel shape of finely goffered (frilled pleats) linen.